Cultural Preservation Through Digital Access and Community Building: The Kentucky Hispanic Heritage Project

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The Kentucky Hispanic Heritage Project (KHHP) is an open-access bilingual digital space dedicated to the history, culture, achievements, and contemporary experience of people of Hispanic descent living in Kentucky. The project brings together sources that document the history of a community that has played an important role in the cultural and economic success of the state over the last three decades. In this presentation, our co-collaborators will discuss the evolution and future directions of the project, highlighting how a backwards design approach informed by community input has guided decision making about accessibility and source selection, positioning the project as an example of engaged digital scholarship that celebrates and facilitates the production of knowledge by the community that it serves.

From the start, our approach to this project has been informed by the belief that documenting Hispanic heritage, culture, and placemaking in Kentucky will increase opportunities, support, and equity for those whose collective history we seek to tell. Following a notable increase in migration and settlement beginning in the early 1990s (Miranda / Rich 2005: 187), Kentuckians who identify as Latino today account for 2.9% of the total state population (Migration Policy Institute: np), and as much as 6.8% and 9.4% in the two largest metropolitan areas of Louisville and Lexington, respectively (United States Census Bureau: np) In one of the first demographic studies published on the emerging Hispanic population in Lexington in 2002, Marta Miranda and Brian Rich categorize the overall community response to the influx of Latinos into the community as xenophobic, paternalistic, ambivalent, and "at best a rather benign neglect and lack of concern" (Miranda / Rich 2005: 205). Today, community activists in our state increasingly call for a move away from demographic and economic narratives and toward a greater recognition of the cultural contributions that those of Hispanic descent make (Blackford 2017: 1A / Meza de los Santos 2019: np / Salinas Chacón 2019: 4C). The extensive variety of sources we have indexed so far evidence this contribution, countering narratives that seek to isolate and marginalize Hispanic people from political, social, and cultural spheres of our Kentucky communities.

The interdisciplinary nature of KHHP allows the project to better articulate different ways that the humanities can address pressing social concerns, one of the primary tenets of work in the Public Humanities (Fisher 2023: np). At the three-year mark of this project, we have identified over 400 sources that fall into the categories of academic research, statistical and demographic information, oral history projects, creative and personal narrative, journalism, and Spanish-language media outlets. We have also identified large amounts of web content that is at risk of disappearing if not archived in some way, for example event posters and announcements shared via social media, video and images uploaded by community members and non-profit organizations, and podcast episodes shared by individuals without institutional backing. Together, these sources offer an incredibly nuanced and detailed history of Hispanic immigration, settlement, and community building in Kentucky. As a space to share and celebrate the diversity and placemaking practices that have helped Kentucky's Hispanic community grow and flourish, KHHP provides evidence that can support grant writing, research, programming, policy-making, and instruction that is better informed and more representative of the diverse experiences and histories that define Hispanic heritage in the state.

KHHP approaches this mission using a Backward Design model rooted at the intersection of Public and Digital Humanities with Community Engaged Research. Digital heritage projects about Hispanic and Latino communities in the United States act as "sites for recuperating lost voices, for

breaking out of the disciplinary formations that have made sense of cultural history to find new patterns, and for increasing participation in the production of knowledge itself" (Kreitz 2017: 305). KHHP can be understood as part of an emerging trend in digital scholarship that seeks to preserve and promote the history and culture of Latino and Hispanic communities at the local, state, and regional levels. Projects such as the (CO), the , the (MA), and (Oakland, CA) index and provide access to various source types, while others such as (University of Texas Austin), the (University of Nebraska), (UNC Chapel Hill), and (Xavier University) focus their collection and preservation efforts on oral histories. These sites question what Kreitz calls "the assumptions and omissions of our print-dominated past" by providing direct access to individual stories of immigrant experience and success in their local communities.

Supported by funding from the UNITE (UNited In True Equity Research Priority Area at the University of Kentucky) grant program, we recently launched a new website at that makes source indexing more accessible and provides the program with a more independent and unique identity. Given that 3.5% of Kentuckians report speaking Spanish at home, and 43.6% of the Spanish-speaking population reports speaking English "less than very well" (United States Census Bureau: np) maintaining a bilingual site has been a priority since the project's inception. Our current site offers users a fully bilingual interface and a variety of ways to browse and search the materials in our collection in either English or Spanish. Users can choose to browse materials by source type, language of publication, or enter keywords to tailor the search to their interests. Hyperlinks lead users directly to open-access sources as available, and to the University of Kentucky Libraries' catalogue record as needed for periodical, print, and online journals. The open search interface is complemented by links to blogs that provide thematic bibliographies and oral history projects directed by the project's co-collaborators. Our primary index is housed on Airtable, where we archive PDFs of all textual and visual sources.

Community input is essential to ensuring that the project is not only accessible and useful to our target public, but also positioned to facilitate community participation in the production of knowledge about its own history and experience. As part of the UNITE grant we are currently conducting a survey to gain insight on who might use the site and how. Initial results reveal trends that both affirm the program mission and provide inspiration for future directions. Many respondents appreciate the simplicity of the site and the easy searching functionality, while others like that it provides a centralized location to find information about Hispanic people in Kentucky. Most survey respondents have been from Educational (55%) and Social Services (40%) organizations followed by Language Services (25%) and Artistic & Cultural (20%) organizations. 80% of respondents have indicated that Community Resources and Educational Resources are the types of content that are most helpful to their organization, followed by Materials in Spanish (75%) and Statistics (65%). We also now know more about how our users would utilize the site to support their organization, with most indicating Educational Purposes (75%), To Support Grant Writing (50%), and To Facilitate Networking (50%). Respondents have given us ideas of content that they would like to see added to the site, such as information about mental health services, employment and housing rights, immigration data, and profiles of Latinx people in Kentucky. Perhaps one of the most valuable survey questions asks respondents what general changes they would recommend. Growing and diversifying the development team, convening a Latino focus group, enabling community member submissions, improving site navigation, and adding more visual appeal are just some of the suggestions we have received thus far. There were also several comments about the importance of representing other parts of Kentucky outside of the Louisville and Lexington areas.

Throughout all stages of the project, we have steadily worked toward the goal of developing and supporting engaged public programs and research, of not simply transferring knowledge but rather actively cultivating exchange and sharing of the creation of knowledge between KHHP and community partners (Fisher). Our experiences thus far, combined with our survey data, impels us to be responsive to our users and prioritize other goals like establishing strong community partnerships, using the site to elevate and promote Latinx voices and success, and add more recent content to the database, especially quantitative data. As we work to address the feedback we have received, we hope that in the long run we can better articulate not just the important work of Hispanic placemaking in our state, but also the valuable role that the digital humanities play in broadening and strengthening narratives of diversity, equity, and inclusion.

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